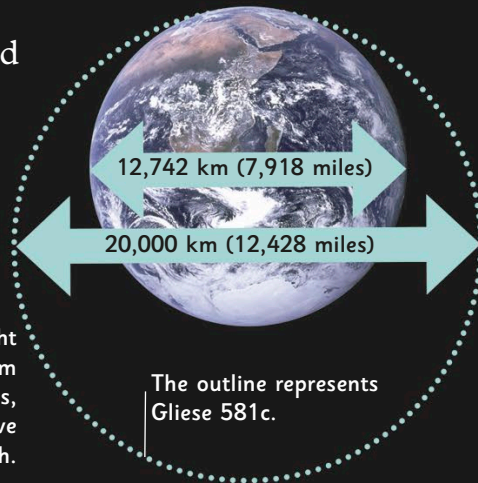


Compared to the Earth

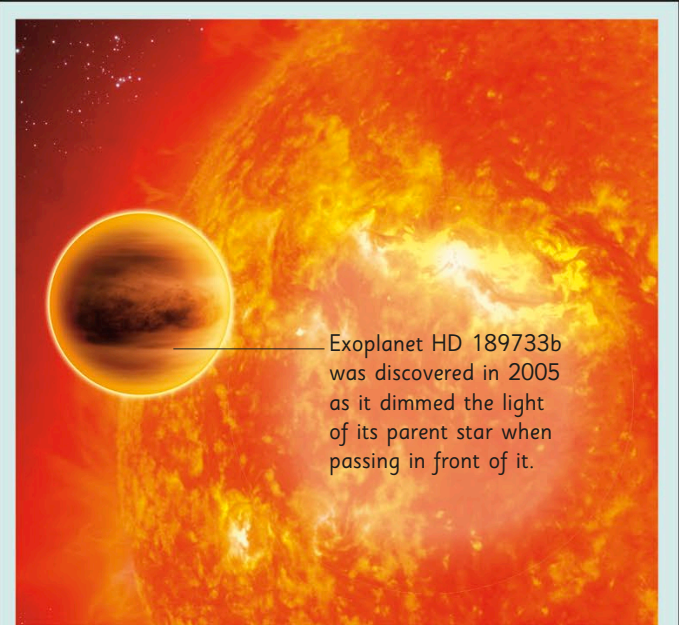
The planets we find are so distant that it is difficult to be sure of their size or their composition.

Gliese 581c is thought to be about 20,000 km (12,428 miles) across, with a mass about five times that of the Earth.



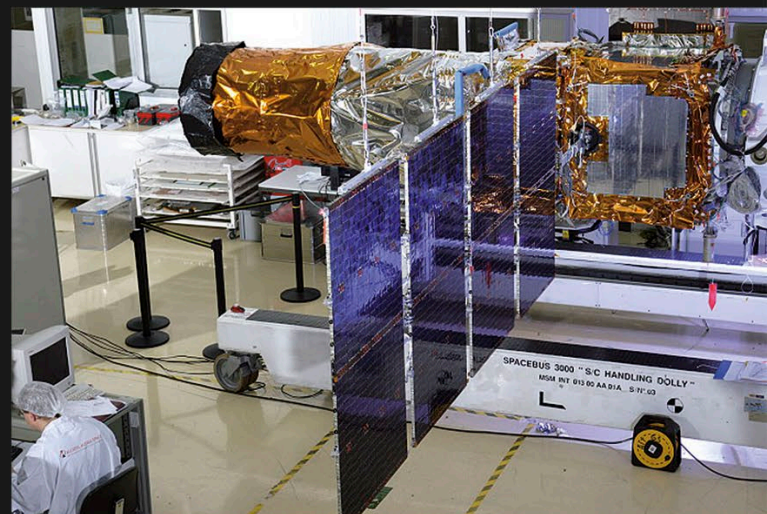
The quest for habitable planets

The *Kepler* spacecraft was launched by NASA in 2009 to discover Earth-like planets orbiting other stars. It has discovered more than 1,000 exoplanets, or extrasolar planets, in our region of the Milky Way.



Are there others?

Exoplanets are planets orbiting a star other than our Sun. About 2,000 have been identified since the first one was discovered in 1992. Astronomers believe there are many more. Exoplanets cannot be seen through a telescope. One way they are found is by looking for a star's "wobble", or shift in the colour of its light, as it is affected by an orbiting planet.



Other space telescopes that are looking for planets include Europe's *CoRoT* satellite, seen here before launch. It worked from 2007 to 2013, and in that time discovered 32 exoplanets.